

Working-session *synthesis*

Meeting #6 · July 1, 2026 — locking it in.

Meeting #6 · Wednesday July 1, 2026. Present: Mario Ramos (Chairperson) and Pedro Rosa (Facilitator). A focused two-person working session; other committee members (Munchie, Elliott, Ray) referenced but not present. **Format:** Recorded plan walk-through — the live working document taken top to bottom, each item moved to *locked*, *done*, or *held*. Closed with a plan to onboard Mario onto the tooling. Intended to feed back into the canon.

TL;DR

This was an execution-and-lock session. With the debit card now active and the .com live on the Chase Zelle setup, most of what was pending on June 24 either closed or got a firm date. The **summer retreat is booked** — the weekend of **August 16–17**, roughly \$1,000 for the group before food and gas, held with a 20% deposit — on the strength of a lesson the committee explicitly adopted: *lock the date, then let people arrange around it, rather than chasing a perfect time for everyone*. The **college visit shifted to a cleaner approach**: the young men **self-register directly on the Illinois State site** (on a laptop at the park tomorrow), which drops the committee as a bottleneck and puts each scholar straight into the school's communication loop; the target moved to **July 13 or 14** for the 11 AM slot. The **Washington send-off mechanism is fully specified** — a dedicated entity Amazon account, scholars share a wish list against a ~\$300 ballpark, purchases ship straight to them, with the program's required-items list as the check — and it's on a clock: set up and instruct by the weekend, buy as early as Monday, depart July 26. On infrastructure, the committee **chose one bank account plus Xero** (free accounting software) to segment the two funds rather than opening a second Chase account, and settled on a **Zelle-only donation site for this year** to sidestep card-processing fees. Intakes are done; consent forms go out tomorrow now that dates are near-locked. The session ended on the autonomy step: Pedro setting Mario up on the business email, Drive, and the AI so he can give the plan real-time status updates himself.

1. Four initiatives — mostly locked

The four-initiative set held from June 24 (college visit, summer retreat, Washington send-off, ballgame). This session was less about deciding *whether* and more about pinning *when* and *how*. Three of the four now have firm mechanics or dates; the fourth (the ballgame) stays deliberately loose. A new **2027 seed** also surfaced and was captured (see §2).

2. College visit — scholars self-register; date narrowed

The approach changed for the better. Rather than the committee registering the group, **each young man registers himself directly on the Illinois State site** — Mario brings a laptop to the park tomorrow and they fill it out on the spot (a two-minute questionnaire). The reasoning: it puts each scholar into the school's own communication loop (flyers, reminders, "see you next week"), and removes the committee

as the bottleneck. Whoever can't attend still fills it out; all Mario needs back is a firm head count of who's actually going.

- **Date target narrowed to July 13 or 14** (to catch the 11 AM slot). *(This supersedes the June 24 "July 6–7" target and the earlier lean toward a paid \$12 group visit — the free self-registration route was chosen instead.)*
- **Funding is covered** — gas and incidentals are in hand. Mario will also buy the group **t-shirts** (~\$14.50 each, ~\$75 for five), as he's done on past trips, on the card — a small camaraderie touch that reinforces the connection this initiative is really about.
- **Cohort is growing:** ~6 solid, potentially 6–7 with one scholar's younger brother (whose mother asked for him to come), potentially 7–8 with an older prospective participant (a Triton student). Two cars still cover it (3–4 each); a third car only if the number jumps — Mario will give a heads-up.
- **Chaperones:** Mario, Munchie, and Pedro attending — a comfortable 1-to-2 adult-to-scholar ratio.
- **2027 seed (captured):** an Illinois State advisor noted that 15–16 is an ideal age for a general visit, because scholars who develop a specific interest (engineering, accounting, teaching) can return for a **major-specific department visit** in a later year. Logged as a future initiative — get the young men thinking about majors.

What's left is execution: self-registration tomorrow → head count → confirm cars and chaperones.

3. Summer retreat — booked for August 16–17

Mario made the call to **Mecan River Outfitters & Lodge**. July is fully booked and the big cabin has limited availability, but **one August weekend was open — the 16th–17th** — and the committee decided to **lock it**. The operating lesson, stated plainly and adopted going forward: *give everyone notice but lock the date; don't try to find the one time that works for all*. If only four or five scholars make the first one, that's fine — they come back and spread the word, and the next initiative fills more easily.

- **Budget:** roughly **\$1,000** for a group of ~10 — two nights' lodging (~\$200/night), a river day with white-water rafting (~\$60/head), and transportation. Food is separate (the lodge serves food; the group can do its own thing one night). **All-in with gas and food is expected to stay under ~\$2,000.**
- **Hold:** a **20% deposit** reserves it.
- **Shape of the weekend:** on the road around noon Friday, check in ~3 PM, a full Saturday, breakfast and checkout Sunday.
- **Lodging:** multiple cabin sizes — scholars in one, adults in an adjacent cabin close enough to check in and hang out. Chaperones: Pedro, Mario, Munchie, Elliott, Ray (Eric a maybe).
- **Backup:** a family-owned, tucked-away lodge in the Wisconsin Dells (indoor pool, cabin feel) that Mario stayed at recently.

Venue note. *The committee expects to book Mecan River Outfitters & Lodge — the lead venue since June 24 — for Aug 16–17; the reservation is not yet finalized. ("Kickapoo," heard in the recording, referred to the earlier backup and was a mis-hearing.)*

Next step: pay the 20% deposit to hold Aug 16–17, then announce the date.

4. The ballgame — held, by design

Unchanged and intentionally loose. It stays on hold until the college-visit and retreat dates are firm; then the committee finds the gap (possibly the first week of August, or on either side of the retreat) and grabs tickets. No action this session.

5. Washington send-off — mechanism fully specified, on a clock

With the card now active, the Amazon mechanism from June 24 got fleshed out end to end:

- **A dedicated entity Amazon account** is created under `mario.ramos@lafamilia.community` with the card attached (a clean, reusable channel for any future scholar purchases — and since Amazon doesn't allow multiple users on one account, a separate account is the right move; ~\$15/mo if Prime).
- **How it flows:** each scholar builds a **wish list on their own or a parent's existing Amazon account** (like a store registry), sets the ship-to address, and **invites the entity account to the list**. Mario gets an email, logs in, reviews, checks the items he'll cover, and pays — and it ships **straight to the scholar**. It doesn't have to be real-time, though Mario may sit with them to prioritize ("you've got a lot here — what's most important?").
- **Guardrails:** the committee holds the program's **required-items list** (Munchie photographed it), so purchases can be checked against the guidelines; a **~\$300 ballpark cap** encourages the scholars to shop with discretion, with room for Mario's judgment if something runs slightly over. Nothing egregious expected.
- **Attire:** business-casual plus about two jackets and at least one decent pair of shoes (all available on Amazon). For expensive one-time pieces, scholars can borrow jackets from Pedro's, Remy's, or Mario's closets and wear their own pants.
- **Timeline:** set up the account and instruct the scholars **by this weekend**; purchase **as early as Monday** — a 3–4 week cushion before the **July 26 departure**.

Next step (Pedro/Mario): stand up the entity Amazon account; tell the scholars to build and share their wish lists this weekend.

6. Infrastructure — the plumbing came online

- **.com is live**, and **Mario has given it to Chase** — the Zelle setup now runs on the .com (a test still to be run). This closes the June 24 blocker.
- **The Chase card is active** (an additional card is available but on hold). Operating rule: **pay everything on the card** so expenses register automatically; for any cash/off-card purchase, **snap the receipt** (under ~\$25 a receipt isn't strictly needed, but still log it).
- **Workspace onboarding:** Pedro to set Mario up on the **business email and Google Drive** (and confirm his photo-to-Drive sync), so official documents can be photographed and filed.

- **Accounting software — Xero (chosen):** a free startup accounting tool that reads the single bank account and lets the committee view and **segment the two funds** without a second account. It also becomes the basis for a clean, public-facing expense recap after each initiative (annotated transactions rendered into a simple site, rather than a raw screenshot). *(Pedro to confirm Xero is the best free option.)*

7. Forms & minor protections

- **Intake sheets — done.** Printed, distributed, and the completed intakes collected; Mario to photograph/scan them into Google Drive.
- **Consent forms — going out tomorrow.** They weren't distributed yet; now that dates are near-locked (**July 13/14** college, **Aug 16–17** retreat), Mario hands them out at the park tomorrow and screenshots them to anyone absent. Munchie prints a few more with the specific dates written in; Pedro then takes them to parents.
- **Digitization goal (Pedro):** turn the intake and consent into **online forms** parents can fill from a link. The intake is easy; the one hurdle on consent is a **digital signature** (not always free — possibly available through Google Workspace, otherwise a service like DocuSign). Pedro to research.
- **Background checks — Year 2, unchanged.**

8. Legal & financial

- **Signature protocol** reaffirmed: sign "on behalf of La Familia Community Scholarship [LLC]."
- **Two funds — one account, revised.** Rather than opening a second Chase account, the committee will keep **one account and use Xero to segment the General Mission Fund and the Discretionary Fund**. This resolves the June 24 open question.
- **Gift posture** reaffirmed: friends-and-family gifts stay informal; a donor giving in the low-thousands — the committee's working trigger is **~\$5,000** — should sign the **gift acknowledgment** (already on hand). Senders write "gift" in the Zelle memo.
- *A useful clarification surfaced:* the **parental consent** form is the one that needs a signature; the **intake** and **gift-acknowledgment** forms do not (the gift acknowledgment can be a simple written statement).
- **Funding:** ~\$1,500 already in hand and effectively covering the summer, so the "raise more" action item can be closed for now.

9. Donation site — Zelle-only for this year

Pedro plans to build the donation site **this weekend**, alongside the digitized intake form. The decision for this year is **Zelle-only** — it keeps things simple and avoids card-processing fees (~3%) and the "who eats the fee" question. Credit-card/Stripe options can be added later, possibly with a donor "cover the fee" choice. The consent form's e-signature is the one remaining research item before the full set is link-and-fill.

10. Branding & outreach

- **Logo:** Munchie and his daughter are working on it. **Manage expectations** — whatever they produce, Pedro runs it through an LLM to clean and optimize the image (reducing hidden file bloat, tightening the mark), so the result may look slightly different; they should take it as far as they like without sweating every detail. The **two-scale** requirement was reaffirmed: a **small, simple mark** (used most — cards, shirts, form corners, interior web pages) plus a **larger version** (e.g., a homepage hero).
- **Business cards:** once the small mark is ready, order cards (Munchie already pricing) with **QR codes** for scan-and-go donating.
- **Instagram:** neither Pedro nor Mario knows the platform well; Munchie and his daughter may take it on. Held as an open item with a **due date tied to the first event** (college visit or retreat), so there's real-time content to post.

11. Toward Mario's autonomy

The session closed on the next autonomy step: Pedro setting Mario up on his phone (business email, Google Drive) and introducing him to the AI tooling — showing how Mario can give the plan **real-time status updates himself** ("I just finished this," "this is halfway done") and ask it where things stand, rather than waiting week to week. Low-hanging fruit now, with room to grow as the initiative count does.

Action items

Pedro (Facilitator) – Stand up the **entity Amazon account** (mario.ramos@lafamilia.community, card attached). – Set Mario up on the **business email + Google Drive** (and confirm the AI-tooling walkthrough). – **Build the donation site (Zelle-only)** and the **digitized intake form** this weekend. – **Research the consent-form e-signature** (Google Workspace vs. DocuSign) and **confirm Xero** as the accounting tool. – Hard-code any consent details Mario texts over; **test the Chase Zelle** on the .com.

Mario (Chairperson) – Bring a laptop to the park tomorrow for **scholar self-registration**; collect the **head count**. – **Pay the 20% deposit** to lock the retreat (Aug 16–17), then announce it. – **Instruct scholars** to build and share Amazon wish lists this weekend; buy as early as Monday. – **Hand out consent forms** tomorrow (screenshot to those absent); write in the trip dates. – **Photograph/scan the collected intakes** to Google Drive; buy the group t-shirts on the card.

Munchie – Print a few more **consent forms** with the specific dates. – Continue the **logo** with his daughter; keep **pricing business cards**. – Explore **Instagram** for a first-event launch.

At the park, tomorrow (July 2) – Scholars **self-register** on the Illinois State site (target July 13/14, 11 AM). – **Distribute consent forms** for the July 13/14 visit and the Aug 16–17 retreat. – Relay the **Amazon wish-list + ~\$300 ballpark** to the send-off scholars.

Open decisions (status)

#	Item	Status
1	Summer-retreat dates	Resolved — booked for Aug 16–17 (20% deposit to hold)
2	Second bank account vs. single-account separation	Resolved — one account + Xero to segment the two funds
3	College-visit registration path	Resolved — scholars self-register individually online (11 AM slot)
4	Washington send-off spend mechanism	Resolved — entity Amazon account; wish-list invite; ~\$300 cap
5	Retreat venue confirmation	Pending — expecting Mekan River Outfitters & Lodge; reservation not yet finalized
6	Consent-form e-signature / form digitization	Open — Pedro researching (Workspace vs. DocuSign)
7	Fundraising goal	Held open — summer is effectively funded; surplus goes to marketing for the next set
8	Donation-site payment rails	Resolved (this year) — Zelle-only; cards/Stripe deferred
9	Instagram launch	Open — due at the first event (college visit or retreat)
10	EOS as a meeting framework	Parked — the list walk-through is working; revisit later

The date is locked, the card is live, and the young men register themselves tomorrow. From here it's mostly execution.